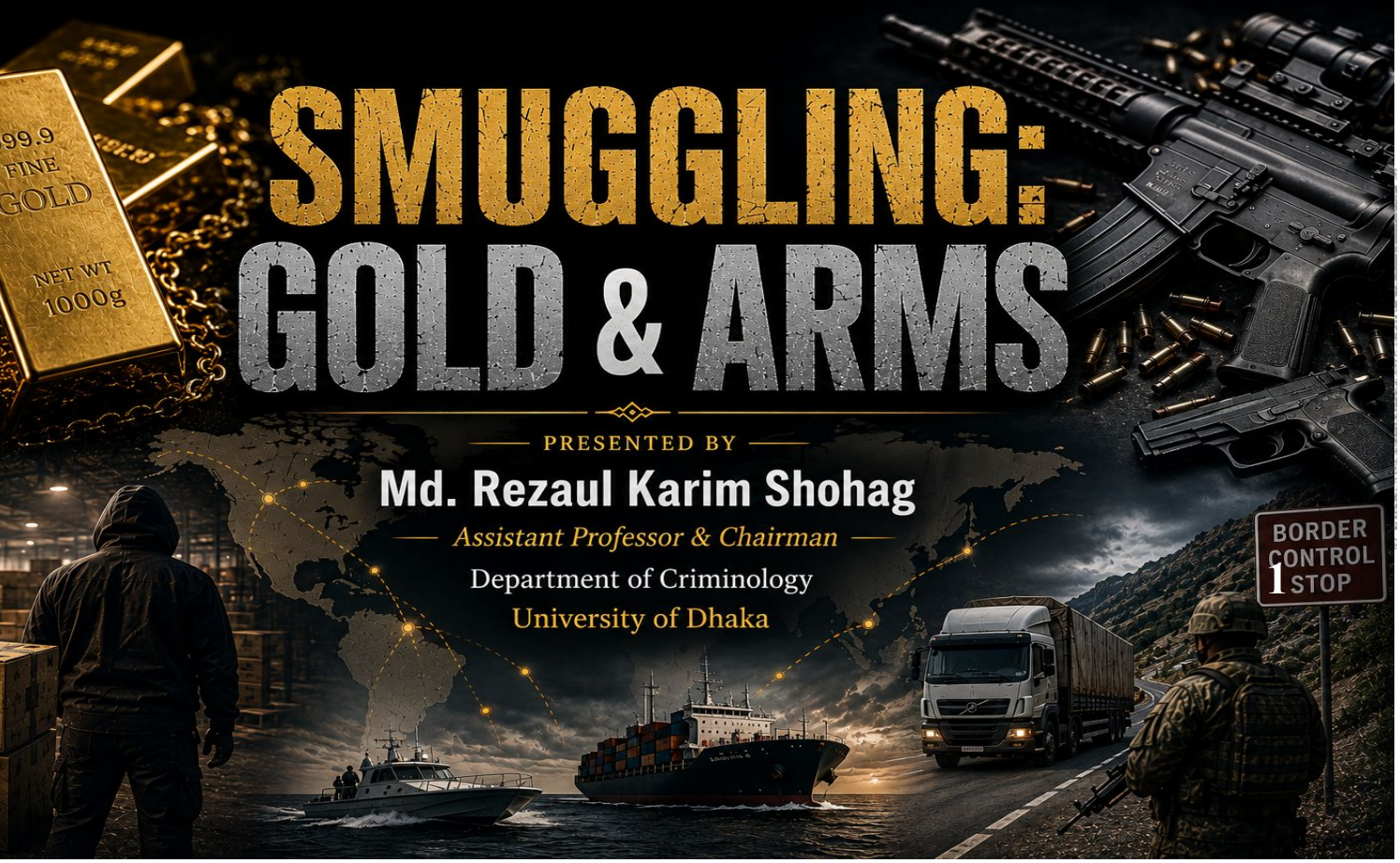

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SMUGGLING:
GOLD & ARMS
PRESENTED BY
Md. Rezaul Karim Shohag
Assistant Professor & Chairman
Department of Criminology
University of Dhaka
BORDER
CONTROL
1 STOP

TOPICS TO BE DISCUSSED

- Concepts of Smuggling
- Types of Smuggling
- Trafficking vs. Smuggling
- Theoretical Explanations of Smuggling
- Gold Smuggling: Motives and Ways
- Notable Gold Smuggling Countries
- Arms Smuggling: Key Drivers & Threats
- Legal Framework, Stages and Routes
- Detection and Prevention
- Case Studies and Suggested Films

WHAT IS SMUGGLING?

- Smuggling is the illegal transportation or movement of goods, substances, information, or people across a border or into restricted places in violation of applicable laws and regulations
- Smuggling refers to the purposeful movement of people or goods across a border in violation of the relevant legal framework (Gallien & Weigand, 2021)
- Smuggling is the illegal act of transporting goods or people across borders, typically to bypass laws, regulations, or taxes (Campbell, 2022)

ETYMOLOGY AND HISTORY

- The verb "*Smuggle*" is derived from the German "*smuggeln*" or Dutch "*smokkelen*", meaning "to transport goods illegally"
- Both terms are associated with the idea of sneaking or secretly transporting something
- Smuggling became a recognized problem in the 13th century, following the establishment of a national customs collection system in England in 1275 by King Edward I (Gras, 1918)
- Medieval smuggling mainly focused on the illegal export of highly taxed goods, particularly wool and hides (Williams, 1959)

MAJOR FORMS OF SMUGGLING

1. Human Smuggling



2. Arms Smuggling



MAJOR FORMS OF SMUGGLING

3. Drugs Smuggling



4. Gold Smuggling



MAJOR FORMS OF SMUGGLING

5. Wildlife Smuggling



6. Cultural Heritage Smuggling



TRAFFICKING VS. SMUGGLING

Trafficking	Smuggling
Involves the exploitation of people for financial or other gain.	Involves the illegal movement of people or goods across borders
Can occur within or across borders	Usually involves cross-border movement
Involves force, fraud, coercion, or deception	Generally involves the person's consent to the movement
Exploitation may continue after movement	The relationship usually ends after reaching the destination
Example: Forced labour or sexual exploitation	Example: Facilitating illegal border crossing for payment

THEORETICAL EXPLANATION OF SMUGGLING

Theory	Origin	Main Points
1. Rational Choice Theory	Derek B. Cornish and Ronald V. Clarke (1986)	• Smuggling is a calculated decision • Offenders compare profit, risk, and punishment • Smuggling is chosen when expected benefits appear greater than costs
2. Routine Activity Theory	Lawrence E. Cohen and Marcus Felson (1979)	• Crime occurs when three elements converge: motivated offender, suitable target, and lack of guardianship • Weak border surveillance can create opportunities for smuggling

THEORETICAL EXPLANATION OF SMUGGLING

Theory	Origin	Main Points
3. Push–Pull Theory	Everett S. Lee (1966)	**Push factors:** poverty, unemployment, inequality, and lack of opportunities **Pull factors:** higher profits, demand, and better economic opportunities Smuggling may result from the interaction of these factors
4. Network Theory	Mark S. Granovetter (1973)	Smuggling operates through social and criminal networks Networks connect suppliers, transporters, brokers, and buyers Trust, relationships, and information facilitate illegal activities

THEORETICAL EXPLANATION OF SMUGGLING

Theory	Origin	Main Points
5. State–Crime Nexus Approach	Jean-Francois Bayart, Stephen Ellis and Béatrice Hibou (1999)	• Examines the relationship between state actors and criminal networks. • State officials may sometimes participate in, protect, or benefit from illegal activities. • Corruption and political connections can facilitate smuggling. • Weak governance may create opportunities for illicit markets.

GOLD SMUGGLING

- Illegal movement of gold across national or international borders
- Avoidance of customs duties, taxes, and regulations
- Can occur through airports, land borders, seaports, and informal routes
- Facilitated by criminal networks, intermediaries, and corrupt officials
- Involves methods such as concealment, false documentation, and undeclared transportation
- Can contribute to money laundering, corruption, tax evasion, and organized crime



KEY MOTIVATIONS

- **High international value and easy portability** – Gold is valuable, compact, and easy to transport
- **Differences in gold prices and taxation** – Price and tax differences between countries create opportunities for profit
- **High import duties** – Smugglers avoid customs duties and taxes to increase profit margins
- **Weak border controls** – Inadequate monitoring and enforcement make illegal movement easier
- **Demand for undeclared gold** – Buyers may seek gold outside formal markets to avoid taxes, regulations, or documentation
- **Money laundering and illicit financial flows** – Gold can be used to move, conceal, or store proceeds from illegal activities

MAJOR WAYS

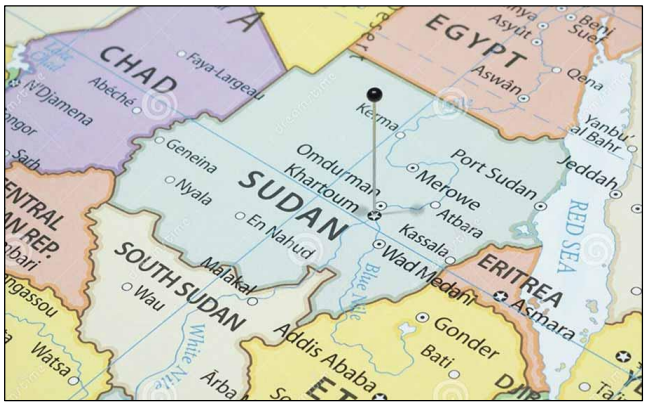
- **Airport and Passenger Smuggling** – Gold is carried by passengers across international borders without proper declaration or authorization
- **Land-Border Smuggling** – Gold is moved through land borders, often using unauthorized routes or avoiding customs checkpoints
- **Sea-Route Smuggling** – Gold is transported through ships, boats, or maritime routes to bypass or reduce customs detection
- **Concealment in Luggage, Vehicles, or Cargo** – Gold is hidden inside luggage, vehicles, or commercial cargo to prevent detection by authorities
- **Use of Informal Networks and Intermediaries** – Smuggling may involve brokers, couriers, traders, and other intermediaries who help move gold outside formal legal channels

NOTABLE GOLD-SMUGGLING COUNTRIES

Regions	Countries
South Asia	Bangladesh, India, Pakistan, Nepal, Sri Lanka
Middle East	United Arab Emirates, Saudi Arabia, Oman, Yemen
Southeast Asia	Myanmar, Thailand, Malaysia, Indonesia
Africa	Sudan, Ghana, Mali, Burkina Faso, Zimbabwe
East Africa	Uganda, Kenya, Tanzania
Latin America	Venezuela, Colombia, Peru, Brazil
Europe	Turkey, Switzerland, Belgium, United Kingdom

SUDAN

- One of Africa's major gold-producing countries
- Large artisanal and small-scale mining (ASM) sector
- Gold is smuggled across porous borders to neighboring countries
- Illicit gold trade provides revenue outside formal state channels
- Gold revenues have been linked to armed groups and conflict financing
- UAE/Dubai is a major destination for Sudanese gold



GHANA



- Ghana is one of Africa's largest gold producers.
- ASM accounts for a substantial share of domestic gold production.
- Gold can be under-declared or illegally exported.
- Smuggling is facilitated by informal traders and cross-border networks.
- Illicit trade causes loss of government taxes and export revenue.
- Environmental damage is associated with illegal mining.

ZIMBABW

- Gold is an important source of Zimbabwe's foreign currency
- Significant artisanal and small-scale gold mining sector
- Gold is illegally exported to avoid taxes and official marketing channels
- Smuggling networks involve miners, intermediaries, dealers, and cross-border traders
- Dubai/UAE has been an important destination for illicit gold



R CONGO



- Gold is produced extensively through artisanal mining
- Eastern DRC has particularly significant illicit gold flows
- Gold can be smuggled through neighboring countries, especially Uganda and Rwanda
- Armed groups have been involved in controlling some mining areas and trade routes
- Gold can become a source of conflict financing
- Weak governance and difficult terrain facilitate illicit trade

COLOMB



- Extensive illegal/unauthorized gold mining
- Armed groups and criminal organizations involved in gold extraction and trade
- Gold used as a source of illicit revenue
- Smuggling through neighboring countries
- Environmental destruction from illegal mining

PERU



- Major gold producer
- Illegal mining is particularly serious in the Madre de Dios region
- Gold can enter formal supply chains after illicit extraction
- Criminal networks benefit from illegal mining
- Deforestation and mercury pollution are major consequences

VENEZUEL



- Illegal gold mining in the Amazon region
- Gold trafficking linked to armed/criminal groups
- Smuggling across borders, particularly toward Colombia and Brazil
- Gold can be used for money laundering and illicit financial flows
- Weak state control in remote mining regions



U TED ARAB EMIRATES



- Receives substantial quantities of gold from African countries
- Illicit or undeclared African gold can enter the formal trading system
- Gold may be routed through intermediaries and trading companies
- Dubai's role makes the UAE important in the global gold supply chain
- Stronger traceability and responsible-sourcing controls can reduce illicit flows

INDIA

- India is one of the world's largest gold-consuming markets
- High demand creates incentives for illegal gold imports
- Smuggling often exploits differences between legal import costs and domestic gold prices
- Gold can enter through airports, land borders, and maritime routes
- Organized networks may involve couriers, financiers, dealers, and distributors
- Smuggling causes customs-duty and tax losses



THAILAND



- More important as a transit, trading, and destination country than as a major gold source
- Its borders with Myanmar create opportunities for cross-border gold trafficking
- Bangkok is an important regional gold-trading center
- Smuggled gold may be associated with tax/customs evasion and illicit financial flows
- Border areas can be vulnerable to informal gold-trading networks

BANGLADESH

- Primarily a destination and transit country, not a major gold-producing country
- **Major source:** Middle Eastern countries
- **Important route:** Middle East → Bangladesh → India
- India–Bangladesh border facilitates cross-border movement
- Organized networks involve couriers, financiers, dealers and intermediaries
- Causes customs-duty and tax losses



Key Routes and Sources

- **Main Entry Point:** Hazrat Shahjalal International Airport in Dhaka is the primary air hub for illegal gold consignments.
- **Primary Origin:** Investigators note that Dubai remains the main source for most smuggled gold, alongside flights from Middle Eastern hubs like Saudi Arabia, Qatar, Oman, and Kuwait.
- **Transit and Border Routes:** The Jashore-Narail highway and border areas like Benapole serve as key internal transit routes to move smuggled gold toward neighboring countries like India.

BANGLADES

- Gold smuggled through airports and land borders
- **Major entry point:** Hazrat Shahjalal International Airport, Dhaka
- Driven by price differences, import duties and gold demand
- Facilitates money laundering and other financial crimes
- **Key challenges** : border surveillance, corruption and informal markets
  Difficulty in identifying organized-crime kingpins

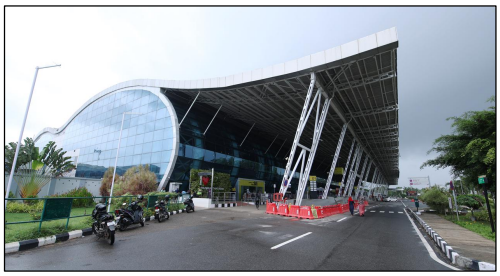


GLOBAL GOLD SMUGGLING ROUTES

- **Africa → UAE (Dubai):** Gold from Sudan, South Sudan & DR Congo moves through regional transit countries such as Uganda, Rwanda, Kenya and Egypt to Dubai
- **UAE/Singapore → Bangladesh → India**: Gold enters Bangladesh through airports and is moved across the India–Bangladesh border, often destined for India
- **Amazon Basin → International Markets:** Illegal gold from Venezuela, Brazil & Guyana moves through regional hubs and air/maritime networks toward North America and Europe
- **Key Transit Hubs:** Dubai, Dhaka, Cairo, Boa Vista and other regional border cities
- **Overall Pattern:** Gold-producing/conflict areas → Transit hubs → Refining/trading centers → Major consumer markets

KERALA GOLD SMUGGLING CASE (2020)

- **Location:** Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala, India
- **Seized:** Approximately 30 kg of gold
- **Route:** Dubai International Airport, UAE → Thiruvananthapuram Airport
- **Concealment:** Diplomatic baggage
- **Key actors:** Smugglers, intermediaries and alleged network members
- **Motives:** High profit, import restrictions and duty differences
- **Issues:** Demonstrates how international transportation systems and legitimate institutions can be used for gold smuggling





BG-148 GOLD SMUGGLING CASE (2026)

- **Date:** 2 July 2026
- **Location:** Hazrat Shahjalal International Airport (HSIA), Dhaka
- **Flight:** Biman Bangladesh Airlines BG-148
- **Route:** Dubai International Airport, UAE → Hazrat Shahjalal International Airport (DAC), Dhaka, Bangladesh
- **Gold seized:** 160 gold bars (18.720 kg)
- **Concealment:** Gold was allegedly placed in the cargo hold of the aircraft.
- **Detection:** Authorities acted on intelligence from the Directorate General of Forces Intelligence (DGFI).



- **Agencies involved:** DGFI, Aviation Security (AVSEC), Customs and airlines security
- **Legal action:** The seized gold was handed over to Customs and a case was registered with Bimanbandar Police Station

DETECTION & PREVENTION

- Risk-based customs screening
- Passenger and baggage profiling
- X-ray and advanced scanning
- Intelligence-led investigations
- Financial investigation and tracing
- Anti-corruption measures
- Stronger border surveillance
- International intelligence sharing



ARMS SMUGGLING

- Arms smuggling, also known as gunrunning, is the illicit cross-border transfer, acquisition, or diversion of firearms, ammunition, and explosives
- The illicit arms trade is estimated to be worth **1.7 billion – 3.5 billion USD** annually
- The black market of arms primarily involves **small arms and light weapons (SALW)** because they are mass-produced, highly portable, and easily concealed



ARMS SMUGGLING

- The illicit arms trade is unique because arms are fundamentally used to exercise power, secure territory, and challenge national security, unlike drugs or human smuggling, which are primarily driven by economic profit
- Arms smuggling poses significant challenges to the socio-economic and political development of states
- It considerably increases the potential for violence among a wide range of non-state actors, including separatists, criminal syndicates, terrorists, drug cartels, and pirates



KEY DRIVERS OF ARMS SMUGGLING

Drivers	Explanations
High Profitability	Illicit arms generate substantial profits for criminal networks
Conflicts & Political Instability	Create strong demand for weapons
Weak Border Controls	Porous borders facilitate the illegal movement of firearms
Corruption	Corrupt officials enable trafficking, diversion and illegal transactions
Demand from Criminal Groups	Gangs, cartels and armed groups seek weapons
Weak Law Enforcement	Limited capacity to detect, investigate and prosecute trafficking
Diversion from Legal Markets	Legally manufactured or imported weapons can enter illicit markets

INTERNATIONAL LEGAL FRAMEWORK

Framework	Subject-Matter
UN Firearms Protocol (2001)	✔ A legally binding international treaty that requires States Parties to criminalize illicit firearms trafficking, establish firearm identification and marking systems, and facilitate the tracing and exchange of information on firearms
Arms Trade Treaty (2013)	✔ Regulates the international trade in conventional arms and prohibits transfers where there is a substantial risk that the weapons could be used to commit or facilitate serious human rights violations

The **1999 United Nations Report on Small Arms** distinguishes between -

- **Small Arms (personal use):** pistols, revolvers, rifles, carbines, submachine guns, assault rifles, light machine guns.

- **Light Weapons (collective use):** heavy machine guns, grenade launchers, portable anti-aircraft and anti-tank guns, recoilless rifles, mortars under 100 mm.

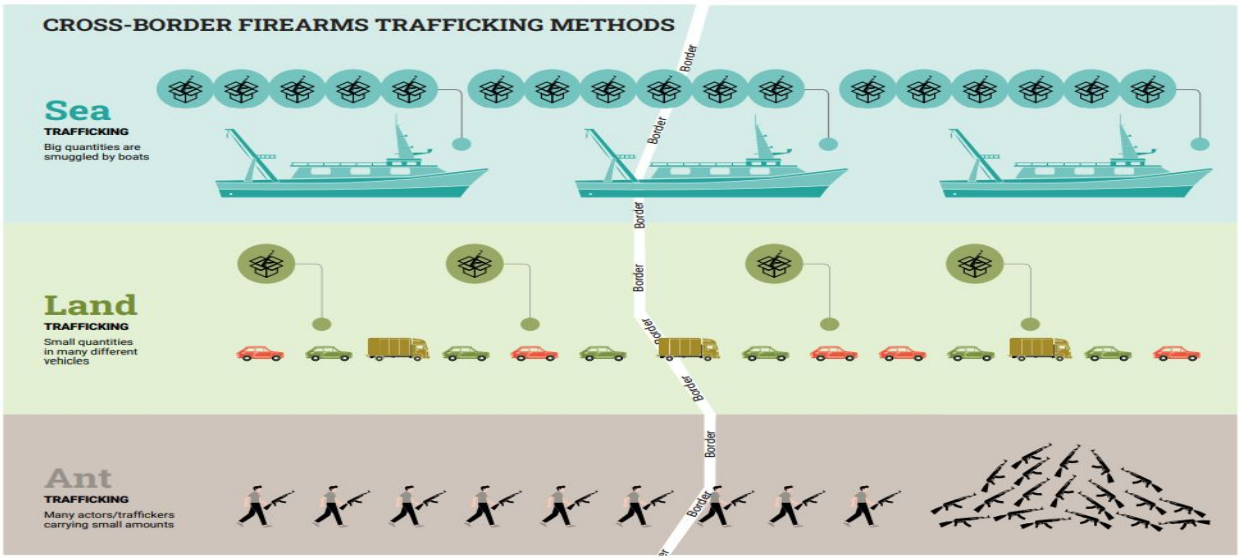
- **Ammunition and Explosives:** integral to both categories.

Authorized vs. Unauthorized Arms Transfers

- **Authorized Arms Transfer**
  - Movement of arms (within or across borders) with **state approval** under national and international law.
  - Includes import, export, transit, and ownership transfers.
  - Governed by instruments like the **Firearms Protocol** and **Arms Trade Treaty (ATT)**.

- **Unauthorized (Illicit) Transfer**
  - Cross-border movement or ownership transfer **without legal authorization**.
  - Examples: unmarked weapons, diversion to illegal end-users, or transfers violating **embargoes and treaties**.
  - Grey areas exist: some government-approved transfers may still breach **international law**.

Cross-border firearms trafficking method



NATIONAL LEGAL FRAMEWORK

Provision	Subject-Matter
Arms Act (1878)	✔ Prohibits the unauthorized import, export, transportation, possession, and dealing in arms and ammunition. Violations involving illegal import or export can result in life imprisonment or rigorous imprisonment of at least seven years.
Smuggling of Arms Act (1934)	✔ Empowers the government to take preventive action, including declaring notified areas and ordering the removal of identified arms smugglers from those areas ✔ Provides penalties for violating government orders, including arrest without warrant and imprisonment, while allowing prosecution under other applicable laws as well

TYPES OF SMUGGLED ARMS

- **Globally:** Pistols are the most commonly seized firearms
- **Americas:** Pistols account for over **50%** of intercepted firearms
- **Africa & Asia:** Shotguns are the most commonly found
- **Oceania:** Rifles are the dominant type
- **Europe:** Pistols, rifles, and shotguns are seized in relatively similar quantities









Methods

- **Diversion from government stockpiles:** Criminals exploit inadequate security measures or corrupt officials to steal or fraudulently acquire weapons from state-held armories and military facilities.
- **"Straw purchasing":** An eligible buyer purchases firearms legally from a licensed dealer.
- **Illicit manufacturing and conversion:** This includes the artisanal production of firearms, the illegal reactivation of previously deactivated weapons
- **Exploiting online markets:** The internet, including social media, online marketplaces, and the dark web, is used to advertise and procure weapons, parts, and components.
- **Theft from civilian owners or dealers:** Firearms are stolen from homes, vehicles, or the premises of licensed dealers.
- **Exploiting the legal trade:** Traffickers use falsified or forged end-user certificates and other documentation to deceive suppliers and obtain weapons

Methods of transportation and concealment

- **Freight and maritime shipping:** For large-scale trafficking, criminals use cargo ships and freight containers.
- **Smaller vessel smuggling:** Smaller boats like **dhows** are used for maritime smuggling, often with smaller crews.
- **Postal and courier services:** Small quantities of weapons, parts, and ammunition can be disassembled and sent through private shipping companies and postal services.
- **Road transport:** Traffickers hide weapons in vehicles, car's structure or gas tank
- **Commercial airlines:** smaller arms by concealing them in their checked luggage.
- **"Ant trafficking":** This involves numerous individuals or small groups each carrying a small number of weapons on foot across a border.
- **Professional concealment:** sophisticated packaging techniques, such as custom-made crates or co-mingling illicit items with heavy, legitimate goods (like timber)

THREATS OF ARMS SMUGGLING

1. War & Armed Conflict

- Smuggled weapons fuel and prolong armed conflicts
- Strengthen armed groups and undermine state authority
- Contribute to violence, displacement and difficulties in achieving peace
- **Example:** In the Sahel, illicit firearms have contributed to deadly violence and conflict around gold-mining areas



THREATS OF ARMS SMUGGLING



2. Organized Crime

- Firearms facilitate homicide, robbery, kidnapping, extortion and trafficking
- Criminal groups use weapons to gain power, control territory and intimidate communities
- Arms smuggling is closely linked to drug trading and other transnational crimes
- **Example:** Mexican drug-cartels rely on illicit firearms to protect operations, fight rival groups and maintain territorial control

THREATS OF ARMS SMUGGLING

3. Terrorism

- Terrorist and violent extremist groups obtain weapons through illegal arms markets
- Illicit arms enable terrorist attacks and armed operations
- Arms can also be smuggled to generate revenue and finance operations
- **Example:** Firearms previously trafficked through illicit networks were used in the 2015 Paris terrorist attacks

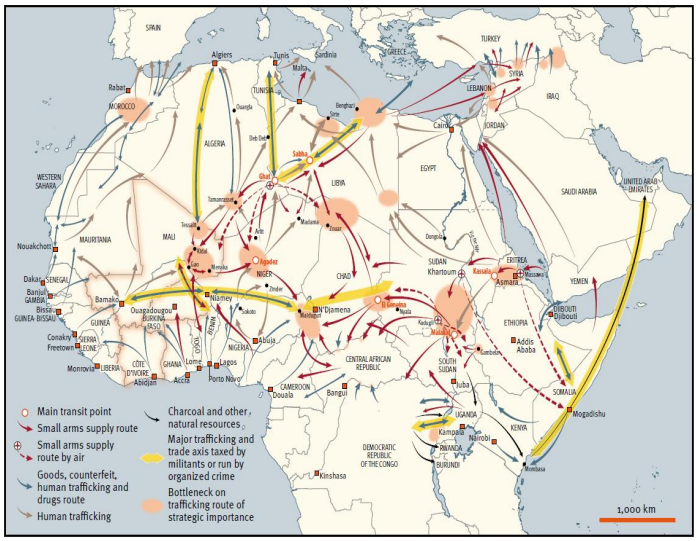


STAGES OF ARMS SMUGGLING

Stages	Descriptions
1. Sourcing / Acquisition	Arms are obtained through illicit manufacturing, theft, diversion from legal stocks, or illegal purchases
2. Collection and Preparation	Arms and ammunition are gathered and prepared for movement through the trafficking network
3. Concealment	Arms may be hidden within legitimate goods or moved using false or misleading documentation
4. Transportation	Arms are moved through land, air or maritime routes, often across multiple jurisdictions
5. Transit / Intermediaries	Brokers, middlemen or transit networks may facilitate movement between the source and destination
6. Border Crossing	Arms are illegally transferred across national borders, sometimes exploiting weak controls or corruption
7. Distribution / Delivery	Arms reach criminal groups, armed groups or other illicit buyers

ARMS SMUGGLING: ROUTES & METHODS

- **Major Departure :** Northern America, Europe & Western Asia
- **Major Destinations:** Central & South America and parts of Western Asia
- **Most Common Route:** Land borders account for about two-thirds of cases
- **Sea Shipments:** Fewer cases, but often involve much larger quantities—around 5× more arms
- **Smuggling Methods:** Primarily concealment, misdeclaration, and document fraud
- **"Ant" Method:** Many individuals transport small batches of firearms to evade detection

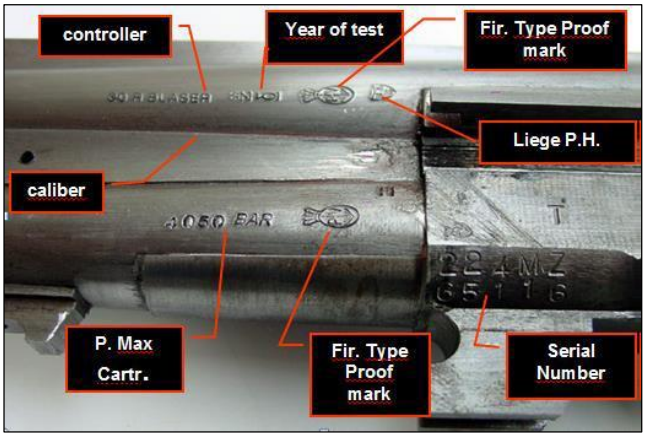


BANGLADESH PERSPECTIVE

Aspect	Contexts
Major Sources	Arms have been reported as entering Bangladesh through networks connected to Myanmar and India, particularly in border regions.
Border Vulnerability	Bangladesh's long land and maritime borders create challenges for preventing illicit arms movement
Key Areas of Concern	Chattogram, Cox's Bazar and southeastern border areas have appeared in reported arms-smuggling cases
Criminal Networks	Arms can be supplied through intermediaries, illicit dealers and organized networks to criminal groups
Major Threats	Gang violence, organized crime, terrorism, political violence and other serious crimes

COMBATING ARMS SMUGGLING

- Criminalize illegal arms trafficking under the Firearms Protocol
- Strengthen investigations and prosecutions of arms-trafficking offenders
- Enforce strict licensing and authorization for the import, export and transfer of firearms
- Improve firearm marking, record-keeping and tracing systems
- Confiscate and safely destroy illicit and seized firearms
- Enhance international cooperation and information sharing among law-enforcement agencies




Thank you!


Any
Questions